

Laser Lites

Also Remember...

- Cartridge life is usually expressed keeping in mind just 5 per cent of the page being covered by ink. The practical life of a cartridge will vary according to type of printing done.
- Duplexing and ADF: This is the ability to print on both sides of a page. It is a useful paper saving feature but usually costs slightly more, although some high-end laser printers include duplexing as a built-in feature.

While laser printers are still primarily used in office environments, they also find appeal where people are looking for fast, high-quality, economical and hassle-free printing. While colour laser printers are way out of the reach of most of us, an entry-level monochrome model is now pretty affordable.

HP, Lexmark, Canon and Xerox are firmly established players in a segment that has seen new entrants such as Epson. Prices begin from about Rs 17,000 for a basic laser printer and go up to over Rs 1,00,000 for a full-blown network printer.

TECHNOLOGY INSIGHT

A laser printer uses a non-impact photo-copier type technology. It uses a laser beam to draw the document on a selenium-coated drum using electrical charges. The drum is then rolled in toner (a dry powder-like ink). The toner adheres to the charged image on the drum and is transferred onto a piece of paper and fused to it with heat and pressure. The final result is just like a regular plain paper print.

SMART TIPS

Resolution: The entry level resolution for laser printers nowadays is about 600x600 dpi. For high-end printers the resolution can be as high as 1200x1200 dpi. In laser printers, a 600 dpi text printout can supersede an Inkjet printer's output at similar resolutions in terms of quality and sharpness, as there isn't any smudging or spreading of ink.

Speed: Print speed will vary according to the type of images and the print mode that you have selected. Laser printers offer speeds much higher than their Inkjet counterparts. Beginning at about 6 pages per minute (ppm), the speed can go as high as 45 ppm or more.



Connections: Check that your computer has the right kind of port for the printer you have selected. While newer models have USB ports, parallel port models are also quite common. For networks, a printer should be able to connect directly to the network and support the kind of protocols you use.

Postscript: It is very important to have postscript support in a laser printer. This can considerably decrease the time taken to print vector graphics—a decided advantage as laser printers are often used in pre-press set-ups and other such graphics-intensive print processes to create colour separation prints etc.

Paper and toner capacity: The cost of consumables can be quite high if you plan not to use refilled toner cartridges. As laser printers operate at considerably higher speeds and handle heavy print loads, it is necessary to have larger paper trays/multiple paper trays as well as output bins. Check that the printer can accommodate the paper sizes and volumes you plan to use.

Memory: Printers come with a buffer (RAM), which is a temporary store for information. A larger buffer allows storage of high-resolution documents or a larger number of regular documents.

	Medium volume printing	Heavy-duty printing
You need	Average output quality and are satisfied with slow speeds as long as it is at a low purchase price	Faster printing and are willing to pay extra for higher print quality
Look for	An A4 only printer with a resolution of 600X1200 dpi	Faster print speeds and higher resolution (about 1200x1200) and the ability to handle larger print loads
Our pick	Minolta QMS PagePro 1100	Lexmark Optra M412, HP LaserJet 1220se
Price range	Up to Rs. 20,000	Up to Rs. 50,000



The Final Verdict on
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